

NOURISH — Postpartum

Phase 3 of 6 — Rebuilding

Postpartum Week 15

A quiet nutrient with important work in every body.

Weekly nourishment theme

Choline, supporting cells, signals, and liver health

“A quiet nutrient with important work in every body.”

Why it matters now

Choline helps build every cell's outer membrane, and your body uses it to make acetylcholine, a chemical messenger involved in memory, mood, and muscle control. It also helps move fat out of your liver. If you're breastfeeding, breast milk carries choline that your baby uses for ongoing brain and nervous-system development.

Your daily reference: The NIH Adequate Intake (AI) — the reference used when evidence is insufficient to establish an RDA — is 550 mg a day while breastfeeding, 425 mg a day for other adult women, and 450 mg a day during pregnancy. ICMR-NIN has no published figure for choline — the same gap this series has already noted for fiber. Rather than trying to calculate every milligram, focus on dependable choline sources across the day.

If you are breastfeeding or expressing milk: If you are breastfeeding or expressing milk, breast milk supplies choline that your baby uses during continuing brain and nervous-system development. The Adequate Intake is therefore higher during breastfeeding.

If you are not breastfeeding: If you're not breastfeeding, choline remains important for your own cell and liver health — your daily reference returns to the general adult Adequate Intake of 425 mg a day.

Where choline comes from: Choline is more concentrated in animal foods — meat, poultry, fish, dairy, and eggs — than in most plant foods. Soybeans, kidney beans, chana, quinoa, and cruciferous vegetables like broccoli and cauliflower are genuine plant sources, but usually in smaller amounts per serving, so a vegetarian day benefits from combining a few of these deliberately rather than relying on just one.

If you eat vegetarian: You do not need one unusually large choline food. Combining dairy or soy with beans, peas, whole grains, and vegetables across the day is the more practical approach. If you also eat eggs, they can make the daily total easier to reach.

About liver health: Choline is needed to move fat out of the liver, and research has linked low choline intake to fatty-liver changes over time — but this is about steady, ordinary intake, not something to worry about after a single low day. A varied diet with regular choline sources is what actually matters.

About heart health: Research has not established that mothers need to restrict ordinary choline-rich foods for heart health. Include them as part of a varied eating pattern and continue following any condition-specific advice from your care team.

A gentle note for this week: The upper limit for choline — 3,500 mg a day for adults, including while breastfeeding — is hard to reach from the ordinary foods in this week's meals. Choline has no known clinically significant interactions with medications, which makes it a simpler nutrient than most in this series from a safety standpoint.

This week's rhythm: One dependable choline source most days — an egg, a serving of meat, fish, or dairy, or a couple of deliberately combined plant sources — adds up more than trying to maximize it at any single meal.

Each day below offers two options, and both are built to carry this week's nutrient — you don't need to mix and match to get a genuine choline source. Choose whichever suits you today — there's no 'right' path between A and B.

If you are managing a health condition

- **Thyroid condition:** Choline has no known clinically significant interactions with levothyroxine or other thyroid medicines — ordinary food and typical supplement use don't need special spacing.
- **Kidney disease:** Ordinary dietary choline doesn't usually need adjustment for kidney disease. Follow your renal team's guidance on any supplement specific to your situation.
- **High blood pressure or previous pre-eclampsia:** The evidence linking choline to blood pressure is very preliminary and shouldn't be treated as a management strategy. Continue your prescribed monitoring and medicines as usual; ordinary food sources don't need special adjustment.
- **Diabetes, recent gestational diabetes, or PCOS:** There's no well-established choline-specific guidance for diabetes or PCOS. The foods this week are fine to include as part of your usual eating plan.

Day 1 — Anchor

Choline builds cell membranes and helps your body make a chemical messenger involved in memory, mood, and muscle control. Both choices below carry a real choline source, not just one of them.

Breakfast — choose one:

- A. Moong-and-vegetable cheela with a glass of milk.
- B. Egg bhurji (2 eggs, yolk included) with toast.

Lunch — choose one:

- A. Whole-wheat roti with a rajma curry and a small bowl of curd.
- B. Chicken curry (cooked through) with rice.

Nourishment break — choose one:

- A. A small bowl of curd with roasted peanuts and guava.
- B. Roasted soybeans with a small guava.

Dinner — choose one:

- A. Dal, roti, and a cauliflower sabzi.
- B. Fish curry, using a lower-mercury fish, with rice.

If you're still hungry: Whatever's easiest to reach for right now.

Day 2 — Especially now, while breastfeeding

Choline is one of the few nutrients in this series whose Adequate Intake is higher during breastfeeding than during pregnancy — worth understanding why.

Breakfast — choose one:

- A. Vegetable daliya with a small bowl of curd.
- B. Masala omelette (2 eggs, yolk included) with whole-wheat toast.

Lunch — choose one:

- A. Whole-wheat roti with a soybean-and-vegetable curry.
- B. Mutton curry (cooked through) with rice.

Nourishment break — choose one:

- A. A small bowl of curd with a handful of peanuts.
- B. A glass of milk with a small handful of roasted chana or peanuts and an orange.

Dinner — choose one:

- A. Moong dal, roti, and a broccoli sabzi.
- B. Paneer-and-green-peas curry with roti.

If you're still hungry: A familiar snack.

About your prenatal or postnatal supplement: Not every prenatal or postnatal supplement contains meaningful choline — many contain little or none. Check your label rather than assuming it's covered. If your supplement contains little or no choline, that does not automatically mean you need another pill. Food can contribute substantially, and any additional supplement should be discussed with your clinician or pharmacist — especially if you already take several products.

Day 3 — Where choline naturally shows up

Eggs, dairy, meat, fish, soybeans, and a few everyday vegetables all contribute — worth knowing which ordinary foods are actually doing the work.

Breakfast — choose one:

- A. Vegetable upma with a glass of milk.
- B. Egg-and-vegetable roll (2 eggs, fully cooked).

Lunch — choose one:

- A. Whole-wheat roti with a rajma curry, and a small bowl of cooked quinoa on the side.
- B. Grilled or pan-cooked fish, using a lower-mercury fish, with rice.

Nourishment break — choose one:

- A. Roasted chana with guava and a small glass of milk or unsweetened soy milk.
- B. Curd with guava and one tablespoon of toasted wheat germ.

Dinner — choose one:

- A. Dal, roti, and a cabbage sabzi.
- B. Chicken curry (cooked through) with rice and a side of mushrooms.

If you're still hungry: A familiar snack.

Day 4 — A nutrient more concentrated in animal foods

Choline leans more heavily toward animal foods than most nutrients in this series. That's simply the honest shape of where it's found — a vegetarian day just asks for a little more deliberate combining.

Breakfast — choose one:

- A. Moong-and-vegetable cheela with a glass of milk and a spoon of wheat germ stirred in.
- B. Anda curry (2 eggs, cooked through) with rice.

Lunch — choose one:

- A. Whole-wheat roti with a chana curry, and a small bowl of curd.
- B. Whole-wheat roti with a chicken curry (cooked through).

Nourishment break — choose one:

- A. A small bowl of curd with steamed green peas.
- B. Roasted soybeans with a small orange.

Dinner — choose one:

- A. Moong dal, whole-wheat roti, bhindi sabzi, and a small bowl of curd.
- B. Mutton-and-green-peas curry with whole-wheat roti.

If you're still hungry: A familiar snack.

About organ meats: Organ meats are highly concentrated sources of choline, but they are not necessary for meeting choline needs and can also be very high in preformed vitamin A.

Day 5 — Away from home

An egg, roasted chana and peanuts, or a bowl of curd are easy, portable ways to keep this week's focus going on a busy day.

Breakfast — choose one:

- A. A peanut-butter-and-banana sandwich, carried in an insulated bag with an ice pack, kept cold until eaten, with an unopened individual UHT milk pack or shelf-stable unsweetened soy-milk pack on the side.
- B. A pre-made egg sandwich (2 eggs, fully cooked), carried in an insulated bag with an ice pack, kept cold until eaten.

Lunch — choose one:

- A. A rajma-and-vegetable wrap, carried in an insulated bag with an ice pack, kept cold until eaten.
- B. A chicken roll, made with fully cooked chicken, carried in an insulated bag with an ice pack, kept cold until eaten.

Nourishment break — choose one:

- A. Roasted chana and peanuts, kept portable.
- B. A small bowl of curd, kept in an insulated bag with an ice pack and kept cold until eaten, with a small handful of peanuts.

Dinner — choose one:

- A. A reheated chana-and-vegetable curry with rice.
- B. A reheated fish curry, using a lower-mercury fish, with rice.

If you're still hungry: Whatever's already within reach.

Food safety: Keep the sandwiches, wrap, roll, and curd all refrigerated or in an insulated bag with an ice pack, and make sure they stay cold until you actually eat them — discard anything that's been sitting out at room temperature for more than about two hours (about one hour in hot weather). Reheat the chana curry or fish curry until steaming hot before eating. Once the UHT milk or soy-milk pack is opened, drink it immediately or keep it chilled.

Day 6 — Small, steady habits continue

Same idea as the past few weeks — one dependable choline source most days, whether that's an egg, a serving of meat, fish, or dairy, or a combined plant option, placed steadily through your week.

Breakfast — choose one:

- A. Besan cheela with a glass of milk.
- B. Egg-and-vegetable paratha (2 eggs, fully cooked).

Lunch — choose one:

- A. Whole-wheat roti with a rajma curry, and roasted soybeans on the side.
- B. Chicken curry (cooked through) with rice and a side of green peas.

Nourishment break — choose one:

- A. Roasted soybeans with banana.
- B. Curd with peanuts and orange.

Dinner — choose one:

- A. Dal, roti, and a mushroom sabzi.
- B. Mutton curry (cooked through) with rice and a side of soybeans.

If you're still hungry: A familiar snack.

Day 7 — Reflection

A quiet week to notice what already felt manageable, and what you'd want to carry into the weeks ahead.

Breakfast: Whichever breakfast felt best this week — worth repeating.

Lunch: Whichever lunch from this week you'd want again.

Nourishment break: Whichever snack worked best for you this week.

Dinner: Whichever dinner from this week you'd want again.

If you're still hungry: A familiar snack, whatever suits you.

Still in Rebuilding. Small, steady sources, chosen consistently, do more for you here than any single perfect meal.

Gentle weekly reflection

Did anything about this week's foods surprise you — anything already a regular part of your meals?

Looking ahead

Next week, we'll look at another nutrient as you continue rebuilding your own strength.

Food safety basics

- Cook eggs, meat, and fish all the way through — no runny yolks or pink centres.
- Cook sprouts before eating them. Raw sprouts carry a real risk of bacteria that washing doesn't remove — skip them raw entirely.
- Choose pasteurized milk, curd, and paneer.
- Wash fruits and vegetables well.
- Use reliably safe drinking water. If the source is uncertain, boil it or use a purifier suitable for the local water risk, and avoid ice from unknown sources when eating out.
- Keep total caffeine under 200 mg a day if you're breastfeeding, unless your maternity team advises otherwise.
- Not drinking alcohol is the safest option while breastfeeding. If you choose to drink, allow at least two hours per standard drink before breastfeeding, and make sure a sober adult is available to care for the baby.
- Refrigerate cooked food promptly, and reheat leftovers until steaming hot, not just warm.
- Choose lower-mercury fish and cook it fully — two to three servings a week from varied types is a commonly used guideline, following any local advisories.